The Makers & Menders Kit

The Pride of Hands-On Work: Building, Sewing, Fixing & Making Things Right

INSIDE THIS KIT

- Conversation Cards
- Word Link Game
- Musical Memory
- Trivia Time
- BINGO
- *Bonus:* Visual Spark Cards

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Why This Kit Works For You & Your Residents

Designed for real Activity Directors who need meaningful engagement without hours of prep.

Recognition Over Recall

Residents are not put on the spot to “remember.” Instead, familiar themes, visuals, and prompts gently spark recognition, allowing participation without pressure.

Dignified & Adult-Centric

Every activity is designed for adults — not childish or overly simplified. The tone, topics, and visuals respect life experience and identity.

Multi-Sensory Engagement

This kit blends conversation, visuals, music, and group interaction to engage different cognitive pathways. Residents can participate in the way that feels most natural to them.

Adaptable for All Abilities

Activities can be used 1:1, in small groups, or larger settings. You can scale up or down depending on cognitive level, energy, and time available.

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How to Run This Session

No prep. No guesswork. Just follow the flow.

YOUR DONE-FOR-YOU SESSION FLOW · 45–60 MINUTES

1

WARM UP

Conversation Cards

5–10 minutes

Gently open the session with familiar, low-pressure prompts. Encourages comfort, participation, and initial connection.

2

ENGAGE

Visual Spark Cards

10–15 minutes

Use imagery to trigger recognition, storytelling, and memory. Ideal for residents who respond better to visuals than direct questions.

3

CONNECT

BINGO or Trivia

15–20 minutes

Bring energy into the room with structured group interaction. Encourages laughter, participation, and shared experiences.

4

EMOTIONAL CLOSE

Musical Memory

10 minutes

End the session with music-based prompts or familiar songs. Creates emotional connection, calm, and a meaningful finish.

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What's Included in Your Kit

Everything you need to run multiple engaging sessions — without creating content from scratch.

6 ACTIVITIES · MULTIPLE SESSIONS · ZERO PREP

Conversation Cards
Thoughtfully written prompts that spark stories and memories. Works in group and one-on-one settings.

Visual Spark Cards
Image-based prompts that trigger recognition and emotional recall. Ideal for residents who respond better to visuals.

Trivia Game
Curated questions based on familiar themes and shared cultural experiences. Encourages participation, not frustration.

Word Link Game
Engaging word association activity that stimulates cognition in a low-pressure way. Works across all ability levels.

BINGO Activity
A familiar game adapted with meaningful, recognizable themes. Encourages group interaction and energy.

Musical Memory
Song and lyric-based activities that tap into emotional memory. Perfect for connection and ending on a high note.

TOTAL VALUE

Multiple activities. Multiple sessions. Use this kit again and again without repeating the same experience.

"Designed to save you hours of planning — while delivering meaningful, dignified engagement."

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SECTION 1

CONVERSATION CARDS

CONVERSATION STARTERS — CUT, LAMINATE & ENJOY

The Workbench

A-1

"Did you have a workbench in the basement, the garage, or out in a shed? What did it look like — was it neat and organized, or covered in projects and sawdust?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

A-2

"What was the first thing you ever built with your own hands — a birdhouse, a shelf, a go-kart, a tree fort? Who taught you how, and were you proud of how it turned out?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

A-3

"Do you remember the smell of fresh-cut wood, or the feel of sandpaper smoothing a rough board? What sounds did the workshop make — the rasp of a saw, the tap of a hammer, a radio playing in the background?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

A-4

"Did you have a coffee can or a jar full of nails, screws, and odd hardware? Was there a junk drawer in the house where everything useful ended up — rubber bands, spare keys, mystery parts?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

The Sewing Basket

B-1

"Did your mother, grandmother, or someone in your family keep a sewing basket? What was in it — spools of thread, a tomato pincushion, a little pair of scissors, spare buttons?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

B-2

"Did anyone in your family sew clothes from patterns — a dress, a shirt, curtains for the house? Do you remember the sound of the sewing machine running and the whir of the pedal?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

B-3

"Was mending just a regular part of life — darning socks, patching elbows, sewing buttons back on? Who was the best at it in your household, and did they make it look easy?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

B-4

"Did you ever pick out fabric at a store — running your fingers along the bolts, choosing a color or a print? What was the fabric for, and do you remember what it felt like?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

In the Garage

C-1

"Did you or someone in your family work on cars at home — changing the oil, replacing brake pads, tuning the engine? What did the garage smell like on a Saturday afternoon?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

C-2

"Was there a pegboard on the wall with tools hanging in their spots — wrenches, pliers, screwdrivers all in a row? Did anyone get in trouble for not putting a tool back where it belonged?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

C-3

"Did you ever fix something that everyone else said was broken beyond repair — a lawnmower, a radio, an appliance? What was the satisfaction like when it finally worked again?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

C-4

"Do you remember the weight of a real steel wrench in your hand, or the click of a ratchet? Was there a particular tool you always reached for first — your go-to for every job?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

The Craft Table

D-1

"Did you or someone you know quilt, knit, crochet, or do embroidery? What were they making — a blanket for a new baby, an afghan for the couch, a set of doilies?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

D-2

"Did you ever make something as a gift for someone — a knitted scarf, a handmade card, a piece of woodwork, a painted sign? What did it feel like to give something you made with your own hands?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

D-3

"Do you remember the rhythmic click of knitting needles, or the feeling of yarn sliding through your fingers? Was it relaxing, or did you have to concentrate hard to keep your stitches even?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

D-4

"Were there craft projects you worked on for weeks or even months — a big quilt, a model ship, a piece of furniture? Did you have a special place where you kept your work-in-progress?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

Built to Last

E-1

"Do you remember when things were built to last — a toaster that worked for twenty years, a coat that never wore out, shoes that could be resoled? What's the longest you ever kept something because it was just made that well?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

E-2

"Was 'waste not, want not' a rule in your house? Did your family fix things instead of replacing them — re-gluing a chair leg, patching a tire, rewiring a lamp?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

E-3

"Did you ever learn a skill by watching someone else do it — not from a book, but just by standing there and paying attention? Who taught you, and what did they teach you?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

E-4

"Is there something you made or fixed that you were especially proud of — something that's maybe still in use, still being passed down, or that someone still talks about to this day?"

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

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SECTION 2

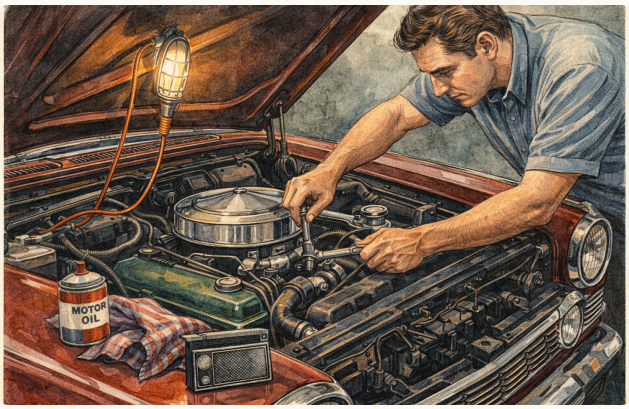
VISUAL SPARK CARDS

IMAGE-BASED CONVERSATION STARTERS — CUT, LAMINATE & SHARE

SPARK 1

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 2



✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 3

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 4

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 5

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 6

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 7

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 8

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 9

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

SPARK 10

✂ CUT & LAMINATE

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SECTION 3

TRIVIA TIME

20 QUESTIONS — TOOLS, STITCHES & THINGS BUILT TO LAST

Tools of the Trade (Questions 1–5)

1. What iconic American tool brand, sold exclusively at Sears for decades, was famous for its lifetime guarantee — if it broke, they replaced it, no questions asked?

Answer: Craftsman

2. What hand tool, shaped like the letter T or L, is turned clockwise to drive a screw into wood and was found in every home toolbox before power drills became common?

Answer: A screwdriver

3. What long, flexible measuring tool, usually made of cloth or metal and marked in inches, can be rolled up into a small case and is essential for both sewing and carpentry?

Answer: A tape measure

4. What small, bubble-filled tool do you hold against a surface to make sure a shelf, picture frame, or fence post is perfectly straight and not crooked?

Answer: A level (spirit level)

5. What heavy, two-handled tool with sharp jaws is used to cut wire, pull nails, and grip things that fingers alone can't hold onto?

Answer: Pliers

Stitch by Stitch (Questions 6–10)

6. What small, round metal cap worn on the fingertip protects it from being pricked while pushing a needle through thick fabric?

Answer: A thimble

7. What brand of sewing machine, with its signature black body and gold scrollwork, became the most recognized name in home sewing around the world?

Answer: Singer

8. What red, tomato-shaped item, often with a little green strawberry attached, is used to store pins and needles and sits in nearly every sewing basket in America?

Answer: A pincushion (tomato pincushion)

9. What printed paper guide, sold in envelopes by companies like Simplicity, Butterick, and McCall's, shows you exactly how to cut and sew fabric into a garment?

Answer: A sewing pattern

10. What type of special scissors with a zigzag cutting edge are used to cut fabric in a way that prevents the raw edges from fraying?

Answer: Pinking shears

The Hardware Store (Questions 11–15)

11. What strong, silver-colored adhesive tape, originally developed during World War II and sometimes called '100-mile-an-hour tape,' can fix just about anything in a pinch?

Answer: Duct tape

12. What well-known brand of all-purpose lubricant spray, famous for its blue-and-yellow can, is used to loosen stuck bolts, quiet squeaky hinges, and protect metal from rust?

Answer: WD-40

13. What type of fastener has a flat head with a single straight slot across it and was the most common screw type in homes for generations before the cross-shaped kind took over?

Answer: A flat-head (or slotted) screw

14. What small, pointed piece of hardware, driven in with a hammer and bent over on the back side, was the traditional way to hang a picture on a plaster wall?

Answer: A nail (or picture nail/picture hook)

15. What strong, two-part adhesive — you mix the resin and the hardener together — was the go-to for permanently bonding wood, metal, and ceramics and came in a double-syringe package?

Answer: Epoxy

Made by Hand (Questions 16–20)

16. What traditional bedcovering, made by stitching together layers of fabric with a pattern of small, even stitches, has been an American folk art passed down through generations?

Answer: A quilt

17. What type of woodworking joint, named after a bird, uses interlocking fan-shaped pins and tails to hold two pieces of wood together without nails — and is a mark of fine craftsmanship?

Answer: A dovetail joint

18. What craft technique uses a single hooked needle and yarn to create blankets, scarves, and decorative items — and is often confused with knitting, though the method is entirely different?

Answer: Crochet

19. What was the name for the type of community gathering where women came together around a frame to stitch a large bedcovering, sharing gossip and stories while they worked?

Answer: A quilting bee

20. What smooth, egg-shaped wooden tool was slipped inside a sock to provide a firm surface for weaving thread back and forth to repair a hole in the heel or toe?

Answer: A darning egg

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SECTION 4

WORD LINK GAME

FIND THE BRIDGE WORD

Read the two outside words aloud. Residents find the single "bridge word" that fits in the blank to complete a familiar compound word or phrase on BOTH sides.

#	LEFT WORD	BRIDGE WORD	RIGHT WORD
1	WOOD	_____	SHOP
2	TOOL	_____	CAR
3	NEEDLE	_____	BLANK
4	THUMB	_____	LE
5	HAMMER	_____	BAND
6	BOOK	_____	ER
7	BLUE	_____	ER
8	SAND	_____	BACK
9	SAW	_____	PAN
10	KEY	_____	SAW
11	DOVE	_____	OR
12	HARD	_____	HOUSE
13	TURN	_____	TOP
14	FLAT	_____	WORK

#	LEFT WORD	BRIDGE WORD	RIGHT WORD
15	**FINGER**	_____	**TOP**

Answer Key

1. WORK	2. BOX	3. POINT
4. TACK	5. HEAD	6. MARK
7. PRINT	8. PAPER	9. DUST
10. CHAIN	11. TAIL	12. WARE
13. TABLE	14. IRON	15. TIP

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The Makers & Menders Kit BINGO

Mark each square as it's called · Five in a row wins!

B	I	N	G	O
Crochet Hook	Workbench	Level	Vise Grip	Leather Belt
Sandpaper	Safety Pin	Thimble	Knitting Needles	Button Jar
Ironing Board	Pincushion	FREE SPACE	Pliers	Hammer
Jigsaw	Toolbox	Duct Tape	Pocket Knife	Screwdriver
Tape Measure	Paint Brush	Quilting Hoop	Sewing Machine	Clothesline

Print one copy per resident · Use coins, buttons, or markers to cover squares

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BINGO Facilitation Guide

BONUS ENGAGEMENT PROMPTS · FOR THE FACILITATOR ONLY

When someone calls “Tape Measure”

Did someone in your house always say 'measure twice, cut once'? Who was it, and was there ever a time someone didn't follow that advice and paid the price?

When someone calls “Sewing Machine”

Did your family have a sewing machine? Was it a tabletop model or one built into a wooden cabinet? Do you remember the hum and rhythm of it running while someone made a dress or hemmed a pair of pants?

When someone calls “Toolbox”

Whose toolbox was it in your family, and did anyone dare borrow a tool without asking? Was there a rule about putting things back exactly where they belonged?

When someone calls “Quilting Hoop”

Did anyone in your family quilt? Was it a solo project in the evenings or a group effort with friends? Do you remember a special quilt that was made for a wedding, a new baby, or just to keep the family warm?

When someone calls “Hammer”

Do you remember the first time you swung a hammer — maybe helping hang a picture or building something? Did you ever hit your thumb instead of the nail?

When someone calls “Button Jar”

Did your family keep a button jar or a button tin? Did you ever sit and sort through all those buttons as a child — looking at the colors and sizes, or using them for games?

When someone calls “Pocket Knife”

Did you carry a pocket knife, or did someone in your family always have one handy? Was it a gift, and do you remember what brand it was — a Buck knife, a Swiss Army, a Case?

When someone calls “Clothesline”

Do you remember hanging laundry on the clothesline — pinning sheets and shirts up in the morning sun? What did the clothes and linens smell like when you brought them in, all warm and fresh?

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SECTION 6

MUSICAL MEMORY

Part A: Finish the Lyric

Read the artist name and the beginning of the lyric. Residents complete the missing word or phrase.

Peter, Paul and Mary (1962)

If I Had a Hammer

"If I had a hammer, I'd hammer in the ___"

Answer: Morning

Dolly Parton (1980)

Nine to Five

"Working nine to five, what a way to make a ___"

Answer: Living

Dolly Parton (1971)

Coat of Many Colors

"My coat of many colors that my mama made for ___"

Answer: Me

Traditional / American Folk Song (1894)

I've Been Working on the Railroad

"I've been working on the railroad, all the live-long ___"

Answer: Day

Tennessee Ernie Ford (1955)

Sixteen Tons

"You load sixteen tons, what do you get? Another day older and deeper in ___"

Answer: Debt

Traditional American Work Song (Traditional)

John Henry

“John Henry was a steel-driving ___”

Answer: Man

Part B: Name That Working Tune

Read the clue. Residents name the song.

B-1

"Lee Dorsey's funky 1966 hit describes the exhausting daily grind of a man doing hard labor underground. He's going down, down, down — and he can't wait for five o'clock to come."

Answer: "Working in the Coal Mine" (Lee Dorsey, 1966)

B-2

"Johnny Paycheck's defiant 1977 country anthem became the unofficial theme song for everyone who ever dreamed of walking away from a bad boss. The title says exactly what he'd like to tell his employer."

Answer: "Take This Job and Shove It" (Johnny Paycheck, 1977)

B-3

"Donna Summer's 1983 pop hit is a tribute to a hardworking waitress who gives everything she's got to make ends meet. The title says it all — she earns every single penny."

Answer: "She Works Hard for the Money" (Donna Summer, 1983)

B-4

"Jimmy Dean's deep-voiced 1961 spoken-word hit tells the story of a quiet, powerful man who worked at a mine. When disaster struck, he held up a collapsing timber to save his fellow miners — and became a legend."

Answer: "Big Bad John" (Jimmy Dean, 1961)

B-5

"The Beatles' 1964 hit, also the title of their first film, describes coming home completely worn out after a long day of labor. But seeing someone you love makes it all worthwhile."

Answer: "A Hard Day's Night" (The Beatles, 1964)

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